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The Disclosure Project

Disclosure: Select Reel #16
Interview with Colonel Ross Diedrickson

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Colonel Ross Diedrickson: I graduated from the Air Force Academy and spent about 7 1/2 years in the Air Force on active duty from 1964 to 1971. I went to work for Mark Marietta first in Denver and then for Rockwell International here in the Southern California area. Then I went to work for FAA in 1974 and worked for them for about 21 years. I retired in 1995 from Federal service.

I was a Traffic Controller; we called it Ground Control/Intercept Controller. I was a Missile Launch Officer and then after that I was an Engineer on the Titan 3 Propulsion System out of Los Angeles Air Force Station. When I resigned from the Air Force in 1971 that is where I was located, at Los Angeles Air Force Station.

Okay, the event, the incident, I guess that I call it, happened on the morning of March 16, 1967. I was on duty along with my Commander, Fred Mywald. We were both on duty at Oscar Flight, part of the 490th Strategic Missile Squadron. There are five Launch Control Facilities assigned to that particular squadron (inaudible) Oscar. It was still dark

out. Of course, we are sixty feet underground and there is no way that we could see out.

As I recall, it was early in the morning. I received a call from my top-side security guard, Pledge Security Control, I think we called them, FSC. He said that he and some of the guards had been observing some strange lights flying around the site, around the Launch Control Facility. He said that they were acting very unusual, just flying around. I said, "Well, you mean, like, UFO's?" I think I used that word, "UFO". He said that he didn't know what they were, but they were lights and they were flying around. They weren't airplanes; they weren't making any noise. They were not helicopters. They were making some very strange maneuvers. He couldn't explain them.

Well, I told him, I just kind of shook my head and said, "Call me if anything any more important than that happens." Then, we just ended the conversation. It wasn't more than, well, within a few minutes I would say, maybe a half an hour later, he calls back. This time he is very frightened, I can tell by the tone of his voice. He is very shook up. He said, "Sir, there is a glowing red object hovering right outside the front gate." I will show you where the gate might be located, but where he is located, he has a large

picture window onto the front gate. He said, "I am looking at it right now. It is a glowing red object. I have all of the men out here with their weapons drawn."

Of course, he is all shook up when he is telling me this. He is very excited. I didn't know what to make of it. But he wanted me to give him instruction or orders, tell him what to do. I think I said something like, "Make sure the perimeter fence is secure." Then he said, right away, he said, "I have to go, sir. One of the guards has become injured." He hung up. Hung up.

I immediately went over to my Commander who was talking a nap, we had a little cot over there for rest periods. I was telling him about the telephone call. As I was relating this to him, our missiles started shutting down one by one. By shutting down, I meant that they went into a "No Go" condition. No Go condition meaning that they could not be launched. So, we get bells and whistles, we get red lights, No Go condition. As I recall at the time, it seemed like every one of them shut down. Later, in recalling this incident with my Commander Mywald, he said that he thought we only lost about 7 or 8 of these weapons that went down into a No Go condition.

Interviewer: Can you describe what these weapons were for the record?

Colonel Ross Diedrickson: These weapons are Minute Man One Missiles. These were, of course, nuclear-tipped, nuclear warhead missiles. So, they started shutting down. Immediately he gets up and we both start querying the status board. We have the ability to query and determine what the cause of the shut-downs were. As I recall, most of them were guidance and control system failures. He started reporting to the Command Post.

In the meantime I called upstairs to find out what the status was of this object. The guard said that the object had left, just left, at high speed. He was apparently trying to climb this barbed wire, but it had nothing to do with the UFO firing anything or injuring this airman.

I asked him what the object looked like and all he could say was that there was a general, oval shape, but it was glowing red, a reddish-orange around the object. It was generally oval-shaped. But, he said that it was very hard to distinguish any features on it.

Interviewer: How far away and what altitude was it?

Colonel Ross Diedrickson: He said that it was hovering right over the fence and to me, that would have been within

about 30 feet away from him. The fence was maybe about 8 feet high.

There was another incident that happened just within a week of this or a week after where there were radar reports and quite a few more witnesses.

The Air Force did an extensive investigation of the entire incident and was not able to come up with a probable cause for any of the shutdowns. I have got quite a few witnesses that will testify to that. I have a couple of people that worked on the investigative team and I have correspondence from the fellow that actually organized the investigative team and there was no viable explanation for this.

Each missile is basically self-supporting. Most of them are powered by commercial power, but each missile has it's own power generator. The only connection between the capsule and the missile sites themselves is what we call the "SIN lines" or their Sensitive Information Network (SIN) lines that are basically buried cables. These lines go to the missiles directly, the missiles are not connected to each other. So, having a fault at one site would not affect missiles at another location.

Interviewer: How many total went down?

Colonel Ross Diedrickson: Well, at our site, there were approximately anywhere from six to eight that went down, but they went down in rapid succession, which again, is extremely rare happening. We rarely had more than one missile go down for any reason at all. This was very rare. Weather was ruled out. Like I said, an extensive investigation was done. Weather was ruled out. Power surges were ruled out. There was only one possibility that was looked at by one of the Boeing engineers that did some tests in a laboratory and he thought that some kind of an electromagnetic force or field may have caused a signal to go. But, it would have had to go through these buried cables to each of these missiles.

Let me back up a little bit, after I talked to my guard upstairs and got the information about the other guard that had been injured, my Commander was talking to the Command Post. He finished talking to the Command Post and he turned to me, my Commander, and said, "The same thing occurred at Echo Flight." Echo Flight is another squadron about fifty or sixty miles away from our location. But they had the same sort of thing that happened. They had UFO's that were hovering, not the Launch Control Facility, but the actual Launch Facilities were the missiles were actually located. They had some maintenance and security people out there at

the time and the UFO's were observed by these people out at those sites. Now, they lost all ten of their weapons. All ten.

Interviewer: Was this around the same time?

Colonel Ross Diedrickson: It was the same morning. So, that morning, we lost anywhere from sixteen to eighteen ICBM's. At the same time, UFO's were in the area and were observed by airmen. Those missiles were down the entire day. We have testimony from Colonel Don Crawford who led the crew at Echo Flight and he was there while the missiles were being brought up to alert status and he said that it took the whole day. I am assuming that it took our missiles a whole day to be brought back up also. We got relieved, I went upstairs, and the first thing I did was look in the guard's eyes and I said, "Tell me the truth about this object." He swore up and down he was telling the truth. I believe him, for a couple of reasons. I know he was frightened when he called down here when I looked him in eye and he told me about the situation. I certainly believed him.

Again, I wrote up a report on this incident. It was in my log. When I got to the base, we had to report to our Squadron Commander right away. In that room with our Squadron Commander was a fellow from AFOSI. We had a AFOSI,

Air Force Office of Special Investigation, on the base. He was there in the office with the Commander. He asked for my logs. He wanted a quick briefing, although it seemed to me that he knew pretty much what had happened already. We gave him a quick briefing and then he asked us both to sign a non-disclosure agreement stating that this was classified information and we were not to release this to anybody.

That was it. He told us we couldn't talk about this to anyone, including any of the other crews, our spouses, our family, even amongst each other. We could not discuss this at all. That was the end of that. I was there at Maelstrom for another two years after that and in that time we were never given a debriefing on any of the incident, either incident, the Echo incident or our own. This is very unusual because we got briefed every morning on any of the anomalies that were going on with the equipment. We were briefed and we discussed these technical issues that were going on with the weapons and all of that, but we never heard anything else about the incidents.

These were major happenings, they were major happenings. I have got a telegram, a copy of a tel-ex, which we received under FOIA coming from SAK headquarters to Maelstrom and other bases right after the morning that this happened. It

said that this incident was of extreme concern to SAK Headquarters because they couldn't explain it, nobody could explain what happened. But, yet, we never got debriefed. We were cleared for very high classification because these were nuclear weapons that we were dealing with. We had high clearances, yet, we were never debriefed on this at all.

The only other thing that I might mention is that we did get security incursion alarms at those sites when the missile went down. So, it is a little unusual, well, that is unusual. Because, normally, when a missile went down for something like guidance failure, we wouldn't get security incursion alarms.

Interviewer: What does that mean, "security incursion"? Does that mean that there is a perimeter breach?

Colonel Ross Diedrickson: It means that there is a perimeter breach. That some object crossed the fence or something broke the security alarm system that we had on the perimeter of the launch facility. So, I did send out guards to a couple of those facilities to investigate that.

The only description I got of movement was, like I said, the first telephone call. They had erratic movement of these lights flying around above the launch control facility. Other than that, the guard upstairs said that the object that

was hovering took off at great speed. It just left rapidly, quickly.

The reason I think that this story is very significant is, going back to August of 1966 at Mynot Air Force Base, a very similar thing happened at one of the Launch Control Facilities at Mynot Air Force Base. They had the same kind of weapons system that we had, M1 missiles. This was observed on radar. There was some communication failure. The object was observed over the Launch Control Facility.

That happened in August of 1966 and that is well-documented, that incident. About a week prior to my incident in March of 1967, I have a record of it from the Crew Commander. He got a call from one of his security guards who was out roaming and looking at the Launch Facilities and saw an object very similar to what I just described over a Launch Facility. He reported in. The Commander reported it to Command Post. The Command Post said that they weren't interested in that report, they just didn't even want to take the report.

That happened about a week before ours happened. About a week to ten days after our incident there was a very well-documented incident that happened at Maelstrom Air Force Base. In this case, near Maelstrom AFB, and this was another

one that was tracked by radar, it was observed at relatively close range by a truck driver and a highway patrolman. There is extensive report on that. The Air Force did an investigation and there is an extensive report on the Air Force investigation of this sighting, of this UFO sighting. It flew around the base, near the base, very close to the base. Like I said, it was seen by a truck driver and a highway patrolman.

This incident was reported back to headquarters and there was correspondence going back and forth. I have got some of that. So, this was a whole series of things that happened having to do with the same kind of weapons system, the minuteman missile.

The reports that were made to me by my guards were official reports. These were not jokes, they were not meant to be anything but official reports. We were dealing with weapons, strategic weapons, during the Cold War, during the Vietnam War. They were very professional, these guards, and they were not about to be joking when we had weapons down about what they were seeing. These were not rumors, they were official reports. So, if they were recanted for any reason, these men should have been court-martialed for giving false reports, false information, during a very sensitive

incident. None of that happened. None of that happened. These were not rumors.

Bob Kamenski headed up the investigative team to look at all aspects of these shutdowns. Kamenski relates to me in writing, I have it in writing, that at some point he was told by his boss that the Air Force had said to stop the investigation, do no more on this, and in addition, do not write a final report. Again, this is very unusual, especially in lieu of the fact that SAK Headquarters was stating that this was of extreme importance to find out exactly what happened here. And yet, the Head of the Investigative Team was told during the investigation to stop the investigation and not to write a final report.

I heard that many of the guards that had reported these incidents were sent off to Vietnam as a matter of fact. I know for a fact, this I can attest to, that one of the guards I sent out to one of the launch facilities, again, observed an object, came back, and was very shaken by the experience and was taken off of guard duty from then on. He was sent somewhere else. He was just too shaken by the experience.

The people who have seen these objects, they were very emotionally involved. It is something that they have never forgotten to this day. I have talked to some of them and to

this day they have never forgotten it. It has been a life-altering experience for them.

change of
person?

...is November flight and Oscar flight was approximately in this location here, just east of Lewiston.

Interviewer: Can you say that again and point this out again?

Colonel Ross Diedrickson: Okay, here is Echo Launch Control Facility. It is located some 30 miles north of Lewiston. Oscar was another 30 or 40 miles east of Lewiston. November was just south of Lewiston.

Interviewer: Hold that still and I can take a photo of it with my digital camera.

Colonel Ross Diedrickson: So we had a rather ranch house looking facility up topside and then down 60 feet underground was the capsule and this was where the launch control facility was. We monitored the weapons from there. Large concrete and steel door that is blown off during launch, if we had to launch. There is a launch facility support building right next to it. The weapon is here.

Interviewer: Let me get that one also. Okay, got it.

Colonel Ross Diedrickson: He talks about some weeks before my incident, he was also at Echo and this is when he received a report from an airmen on duty saying that there

was something outside of the perimeter fence that he had never seen before. The object was lighted and seemed to be watching the site. It approached and retreated and something circled the site. He had this conversation and he told the guard to go ahead and use his weapon, but the guard said that he didn't think it would do any good. He tried to report it to the Command Post and the Command Post didn't want to receive the report.

Interviewer: A little bit like when I am sewing up someone's face with 6-0 nylon.

Colonel Ross Diedrickson: This is old (inaudible) UFO's.

Interviewer: Can you repeat who this is from?

Colonel Ross Diedrickson: Fred Mywald, he was my Commander during the time of the incident. He confirms that the topside guard observed UFO's. AT the time we lost our missile system. He also talks about the security team that I had sent out to check the security infractions and while in route back they lost radio contact. One of these men, again, as I said, was very upset about this whole incident and was unable to return. He says, "I heard second-hand that one was released from security team duties".

Okay, this is a transcript of a conversation that I had with Walt Feegle who was the Deputy at Echo Flight. He is talking about UFO's hovering the site. He said, "What are you guys drinking out there?" Then, he sent strike teams who didn't know about the conversation here with the guards out at the site and they called back and also reported seeing the UFO's.

Interviewer: And where did this come from?

Colonel Ross Diedrickson: Out of Echo Flight, Eric Carlson. Anyway, he also confirms that UFO's were observed by his security guards out there. Again, the primary witnesses that I have of this incident that will directly verify this story are the Echo Crew, the Commander and Deputy Commander, and my own Commander, Fred Mywald. The other witnesses, that I will talk about, this tel-ex, you see here, there is a reference to a secret message on the same subject. This should be a copy, an exact duplicate, but as you see here under the subject, here there is a reference, and here it is missing. We received these under separate organizations in the Air Force under the Freedom of Information Act.

Interviewer: I want to get a picture of this. I guess that I will have to do one and then the other because I can't get all of that. And we have copies of all of these?

Colonel Ross Diedrickson: He recalled seeing a tel-ex saying that a UFO was seen hovering over a missile silo and observed by missile personnel on duty in 1967.

Subsequently, we were notified a few days later that a stop work order was on the way from OAMA. OAMA is the Air Material Command in Ogden, Utah to stop any further effort on this project. We stopped. We were also told that we were not to submit the final engineering report. This was most unusual since all of our work required review by the customer and the submittal of a final engineering report to OAMA.

This is correspondence regarding this incident. The Air Force got involved officially between the hours of 2400 and 0400 Mountain Standard Time, numerous reports were received by Maelstrom AFB of UFO sightings in the Great Falls, Montana area. This was assigned to investigation. This was base UFO Officer Lieutenant Colonel Lewis Chase and he actually went out...

...This is a tel-ex going to Air Defense Command and Air Force Base, Colorado, Maelstrom, Wright Patterson AFB, Chief of Staff, Air Force, Washington, D.C. Again, this was a UFO